

Vademecum

This guide is designed to assist students in preparing for their final examination. Before reaching out to your supervisor for clarifications, please review this manual thoroughly.

Using the OneDrive Folder

All document exchanges with the supervisor should occur through the dedicated OneDrive (OD) folder. Emails should be reserved strictly for communication purposes. The OD folder is divided into three subfolders:

- **Literature:** This folder is intended for adding articles, books, and other documents that are relevant to your thesis. Students should upload documents that will form part of the bibliography, while the supervisor may add materials they believe will be helpful for your research.
- **Manuscript:** This folder contains the thesis outline and the manuscript prepared for the final examination. It includes “Word” and “Latex” subfolders, which have the templates needed for writing your thesis in Microsoft Word or TEX (see further details in the instructions).
- **Software:** This folder should contain all data and code used for your empirical analysis or simulation study. Ensure that the code is clean, well-commented, and capable of running correctly from any general directory.

Instructions for Submitting the Thesis

Your thesis must be submitted to your supervisor **at least 30 days** before the deadline for uploading the final document (check the graduation calendar). This allows enough time for necessary revisions. Any exceptions must be agreed upon with your supervisor in advance.

Preliminary drafts submitted during the supervision phase should be fully developed, including all essential components such as the table of contents, chapters, figures, tables, and bibliography. Incomplete submissions, such as individual chapters, will not be accepted. For any queries regarding specific chapters, please reach out to your supervisor via email.

Before submitting each manuscript version, carefully proofread the PDF file to ensure it complies with all instructions outlined in this *Vademecum*. Preliminary versions must be meticulously prepared: concepts should be clearly and logically presented, spelling and punctuation should be accurate, and tables and figures must be properly indexed and accompanied by detailed captions. Citations and references should strictly follow the provided guidelines. The quality of preliminary drafts will be **subject to evaluation**.

Upload every thesis version in **PDF format** to the “Manuscript” folder. Any changes made after each review should be clearly marked in **red** (**not highlighted in red**) to allow easy identification by your supervisor.

Instructions for Drafting the Thesis

Purpose and Content

The final thesis marks the culmination of two years of study and requires thorough attention. It showcases your ability to address and analyze a topic of personal interest within your field, demonstrating scientific rigor and professional competence.

The choice of topic and thesis writing should be approached with autonomy, supported by a supervisor. You must demonstrate analytical skills and familiarity with the technical tools acquired during your studies, convincingly exploring an economic-business phenomenon or a significant theoretical/practical issue.

Your thesis should frame the topic within a theoretical context, drawing on relevant academic literature. It must present and interpret your findings, clarifying how they align with or differ from existing theories.

The thesis should be comprehensive yet concise, maintaining clarity, logical flow, and persuasiveness in presenting your results.

Be aware that plagiarism, i.e., using someone else's work without proper attribution, is illegal and constitutes a violation under Article 1 of Law 19 April 1925, no. 475. The final paper will undergo an anti-plagiarism check, and failure to pass this check will result in the thesis not being approved and the student being excluded from the graduation session.

Structure

The thesis is typically structured into chapters, supplemented by a title page, table of contents, introduction, conclusion, bibliography, and web sources. Each chapter may be divided into sections and subsections, which should be progressively numbered (e.g., the first subsection of the second section in the third chapter would be numbered “3.2.1”).

The introduction, around two pages long, should briefly present the topic, explain its significance, and outline the contents of the subsequent chapters. If the thesis focuses on a specific business case, it is advisable to provide a quick overview of the company under study.

The main body of the thesis is the core section and should thoroughly present and explore the chosen topic. It may include empirical analyses and business case studies. In such cases, it's crucial to detail the methodological aspects, even dedicating a chapter if needed.

Additionally, you should clarify how the information was obtained (e.g., through an interview with a managerial figure, from a database, etc.). It is advisable to structure the main body into: (i) a methodological chapter, which presents and discusses the methods employed in the analysis; and (ii) an empirical chapter, which outlines the research design and results. Depending on the nature of the thesis, the empirical chapter can be divided into two sections, dedicating one chapter specifically to the creation of the dataset, detailing the processes of data collection and data management.

The conclusion should briefly revisit the topic, reiterating its importance, and concisely summarize the contents of the various chapters. This section is crucial, as it serves to tie together the entire work. It should summarize what was done, why the result is significant, the methodology used, and what insights or recommendations can be drawn. In essence, the conclusion is where you highlight and showcase your entire work with clarity and conciseness.

Following the conclusion, the bibliography and web sources should list all the references and websites used during the thesis preparation.

Literature review

Since every thesis should be grounded in a theoretical framework, the supervising professor may recommend a brief bibliography to start with. However, the student is expected to conduct their own complementary bibliographic research, using the professor's suggestions as a foundation.

It is strongly advised to prioritize academic sources or those with recognized scientific value over gray literature (online journals, forums, blogs, social networks, etc.), unless they are publications from prestigious institutions. The more citations from academic sources you include, the more credible your thesis will be. Valid sources include:

- **Articles published in academic journals.** These are papers published in national or international academic journals that contribute new insights to a topic, whether theoretically or through empirical data analysis. You can find a comprehensive list of academic journals and their quality rankings on the SCImago Journal & Country Rank website: <https://www.scimagojr.com/>. This platform provides detailed metrics on journal impact, rankings, and overall quality, which can be useful in identifying reputable sources for your thesis. Many journals are not freely accessible online, but the University of Bologna (Unibo) subscribes to many of them. To access them, students need to use university computer stations or connect via the Unibo Wi-Fi network (Almawifi) with their institutional credentials, from locations such as libraries, classrooms, or study halls. The simplest way to search for academic papers by keywords is through Google Scholar (<https://scholar.google.it>) or Elsevier Scopus (<http://www.scopus.com>). If you cannot connect from a university location, you can access the resources remotely (e.g., from home) by following the

instructions available on the Unibo library portal:
<http://www.biblioteche.unibo.it/portale/strumenti/proxy>.

- **Scientific working papers** (i.e., articles not yet published in academic journals but available online). These are academic articles that have not yet been published in specialized journals. However, many researchers make these papers available online. The most well-known repository for such working papers, are SSRN (<http://www.ssrn.com>) and ArXiv (<https://arxiv.org>), where most articles can be downloaded for free. It's always a good idea to check if a preliminary version of a paper found on SSRN or ArXiv has since been published in an academic journal, in which case, the published version is preferable and should be cited.
- **Publications from reputable national or international institutions.** These are articles published by national or international institutions and research centers with a solid scientific reputation. Examples include supranational organizations like the European Central Bank and the Organization for Economic Cooperation and Development (OECD). The websites of these institutions typically have dedicated sections for articles and papers, many of which are freely downloadable.
- **Scientific monographs and university textbooks.**

These sources should be referenced to deepen the theoretical context of your chosen topic and must be properly cited within your thesis (either in the main text, footnotes, or the final bibliography/web sources section). A later section of this document is dedicated to citation practices, as it's essential to use external material correctly.

Style and format

The basic editorial guidelines for drafting the thesis include:

- The thesis should not exceed 100,000 characters (including spaces), approximately 35 pages of text. This limit excludes footnotes, indices, bibliography, images, and appendices.
- Use Microsoft Word or TEX typographic software commonly used in academic writing. Details on installing TEX are provided in the instructions.
- Use Times New Roman or Arial for Word documents and Computer Modern for TEX documents, with a font size of 12 points (10 points for footnotes). Set 2.5 cm margins on all sides and 1.5 line spacing. Templates are available in the "Manuscript" folder.

Preliminary versions of the thesis must not contain personal comments or questions addressed to the professor. For the latter, send an email outlining the question.

The title, chapters, and sections of the thesis should adhere to a "classic" and formal style that suits academic writing. Avoid using "WordArt" or any similar decorative elements.

The thesis's table of contents should adhere to the outline agreed upon with your supervisor and be organized into clearly defined chapters and sections. Each chapter should follow a logical structure that aligns with the thesis objectives outlined in the introduction, and each section should be coherently structured to support the chapter's main objective.

The introduction of the thesis should provide context for the problem, clearly outline the objectives, and present the overall structure of the thesis. It is recommended to avoid dividing the introduction into sections unless necessary.

Within each paragraph, sentences should be clear and concise. The use of subordinate clauses beyond the first degree is strongly discouraged. Prefer periods over semicolons and pay particular attention to grammatical correctness. Students often write lengthy sentences filled with numerous commas, which can make the sentences overly long and cause the reader to lose track of the main idea. Scientific writing, on the other hand, tends to favor shorter, more concise sentences.

The thesis text should be formatted with justified alignment, ensuring that the text extends evenly across the entire width of the page within the set margins.

Maintain consistency in the style of bullet and numbered lists: each item should start with a capital letter and end with a period. Similarly, be consistent in how you present dates (e.g., "12/1/2003" or "12 January 2003"), figures (e.g., "\$1 million" or "1 million dollars"), abbreviations (e.g., "S.p.A." or "S.p.a."), and your choice of decimal separators (comma or period).

Footnotes should be numbered progressively. Since footnotes contain information considered not essential for the main text, their use should be minimized.

All statements that reference facts, data, or research conducted by other organizations or institutions must be accompanied by a citation within the text.

Bibliographic references should be included in the bibliography at the end of the thesis. Each reference listed in the bibliography must be **cited** in the text.

Any appendices can be added after the bibliography.

Acknowledgments may be included at the student's discretion. They are typically placed at the beginning, before the introduction, but this placement is flexible.

Figures and Tables

Figures and tables must be consecutively numbered and labeled (e.g., "Figure 1." or "Table 1.3."). Each should include a brief, descriptive caption that provides all necessary details for understanding. For instance: "Figure 1: Quantity of fruit exported to Germany in 2019. The unit of measure on the y-axis corresponds to 1,000 tons." Additionally, always indicate the data source below each table or figure (e.g., "Source: Bank of Italy") if data has not been processed in the thesis.

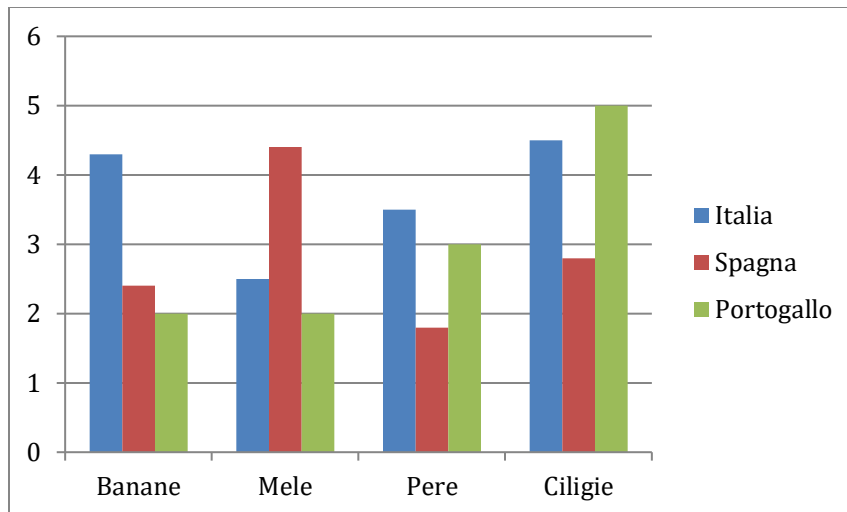


Figure 1. Quantity of fruit exported to Germany in 2019. The unit of measure on the y-axis corresponds to 1,000 tons.

Tables should be created directly within the text and should not be inserted as images unless necessary.

All figures and tables must be referenced in the text to guide the reader on when to view them. Avoid vague expressions like "the figure below," "the following table," or "the table above." Instead, make explicit references to aid readability, such as "As shown in Figure 1" or "Table 2.3 presents."

Math and Code

Incorporating mathematical formalism can often enhance clarity when explaining your methodology.

Ensure that mathematical formulas are inserted using the appropriate editing tools. In Microsoft Word, the "Equation" feature (activated with ALT + =) should be used, while in TexStudio, you can employ various commands (refer to the instructions provided below).

Any output from R (or similar software) should be presented as a well-formatted table within the thesis, rather than as a screenshot or image.

Bibliography

All bibliographic and web sources used and cited in the thesis must be listed in alphabetical order in the designated sections. It's crucial to provide all identifying details of the publication, including the authors' last name and initials, publication year, title of the work, and, if applicable, the title of the book in which it appears (if it's a chapter from a book). You should also include the publisher or journal name, volume and issue number, page numbers (for articles or book chapters), website URL, and the date it was last accessed (for online sources).

Below are some examples of how to list different types of references:

- **For a journal article:** Zhang, J., Yang, X., & Appelbaum, D. (2015). Toward Effective Big Data Analysis in Continuous Auditing. *Accounting Horizons*, 29(2), 469-476.
- **For a book:** Willcocks, L., Venters, W., & Whitley, E. (2014). *Moving to the Cloud Corporation: How to Face the Challenges and Harness the Potential of Cloud Computing*. Palgrave, London.
- **For a book chapter:** Bhimani, A., & Bromwich, M. (2009). Management Accounting in a Digital and Global Economy. In C. Chapman, D. Cooper, & P. Miller (Eds.), *Accounting Organizations and Institutions: Essays in Honour of Anthony Hopwood* (pp. 85-111). Oxford University Press, Oxford.
- **For an online source:** Silvestro, R. (2016). Do you Know what Really Drives your Business's Performance? *MIT Sloan Management Review*, Summer, 1-10. Accessed on July 14, 2016, from <http://sloanreview.mit.edu/article/do-you-know-what-really-drives-your-businesss-performance/>.
- **For a conference paper:** Brynjolfsson, E., Hitt, L., & Kim, H. (2011). Strength in Numbers: How Does Data-Driven Decision Making Affect Firm Performance. Paper presented at the 9th Annual Industrial Organization Conference, April 22.

When listing websites in the references section, include only the top-level domain of the site you consulted (e.g., www.borsaitaliana.it) and not the complete URL of a specific page (e.g., <http://www.borsaitaliana.it/etf/etf/home.htm>).

Final Tips

When writing your thesis, always consider the reader's perspective. After finishing a chapter, it's beneficial to "let it rest" and revisit it a few days later, asking yourself, "If I were the reader, would I be able to fully grasp the content with only the information provided here?" Writers often overlook missing information or unclear explanations because they already have a complete understanding of the topic. However, since the reader does not have the same background, it's essential to ensure that the content is clear and comprehensive from their point of view. Incorporating simple examples can often be very effective in helping the reader understand complex concepts.

Always provide detailed explanations of methodological aspects, especially when using techniques that are not commonly found in standard textbooks for the degree program. For instance, if your thesis includes matrix multiplication, there's no need to introduce algebra. However, if you use a more specialized statistical test or an uncommon methodology, such as the classical decomposition of a time series, you should offer a detailed explanation.

Instructions for Installing TEX and the TexStudio Editor

To use the TEX digital typography software, it is necessary to download and install the [MikTeX](#) distribution. For drafting the paper, it is advisable to install the [TeXstudio](#) compiler, as it has a graphical interface that simplifies the use of TEX.

You will find a TEX template for drafting the thesis in the “Manuscript” folder, which you can load into TeXstudio. The template contains the main commands for text editing, creating tables, inserting figures, citations, and references. It is recommended to overwrite the existing template when drafting the thesis, removing any unused commands.

Instructions for Preparing the Final Presentation

The final examination consists of presenting your thesis to a committee during the graduation session. Approximately one week before the exam, graduates will receive an email with the precise date and the names of the committee members, sent to their institutional email address. On the day of the session, each student should bring a USB drive containing only the presentation file to support their discussion. Some tips:

- Keep your presentation within a maximum of 13 minutes. Practice multiple times while timing yourself, and take advantage of any available classroom space in the days leading up to the discussion for additional practice.
- Ensure that your slides are clear and concise. Opt for white backgrounds, minimal text, relevant images, and tables.
- Due to the limited presentation time, keep the number of slides manageable (around ten is ideal). Clearly contextualize the problem you're addressing and stay focused: if your thesis is primarily empirical, explain the objective and motivation, outline the data collection process, and discuss the results. If it is more methodological, present the objective and motivation, detail the methods, and then illustrate their application.
- Present confidently and assertively. Practice multiple times to build familiarity. If you are interrupted by committee members, respond courteously and then continue with your prepared presentation.